



Whether social media networks will allow business communicators to engage across cultures and bridge intercultural differences will depend on the users' attitudes and openness.

Social Media: Blurring Boundaries? What we make of the potential for positive intercultural connectedness online is as much up to us as it would be at a dinner party where we don't know any of the other guests. Some authors believe that social media used mindfully can benefit mental health, blur cultural gaps, reduce hierarchies, and empower people to change their circumstances.⁴⁵ At the same time, the online environment may deepen feelings of social isolation, leading to depression and the much debated **loneliness epidemic**, only made worse by the COVID-19 pandemic.⁴⁶

Online, as in real life, we gravitate toward people who seem like us, believes social entrepreneur Rajiv Vinnakota. Social media divide us because we inhabit "echo chambers" online instead of "bridging social capital" and interacting with people not like us as we used to do offline, he says.⁴⁷ However, shared causes can mobilize social media users halfway across the globe—for example, the international climate movement Friday for Future or the pro-democracy student protesters in Hong Kong—as they try to win the hearts and minds of the public.⁴⁸

Social Media: Global and Local? Despite cultural convergence—the equalizing influence of globalization on cultures around the world—regional and cultural differences persist, as those who design media for markets in other countries know. Adobe Inc., for example, is represented by 30 corporate websites that are adapted to local country-specific tastes and expectations.

Knowledge of color symbolism across cultures is indispensable for designers lest they commit cultural blunders. Consider that yellow—a hue with generally positive connotations in Western cultures, but one that also represents cowardice—stands for courage in Japan. Orange, the signature color of the Dutch royal court, epitomizes the harvest and fall in North America and Europe. Likewise, in Asia, orange is an auspicious hue; however, in the Middle East, orange signifies mourning and loss.⁴⁹

More serious differences nationally as well as globally are now caused by geopolitical turmoil, cyberattacks by foreign powers, and restricted access to the Internet in authoritarian countries around the world—a trend that has been called **digital nationalism**. Some predictions foresee a so-called **Splinternet**, a fragmentation of the Internet, once viewed as a unified global network.⁵⁰ It remains to be seen whether the deep divides will dissipate or continue to grow.

LEARNING OUTCOME 5

Identify strategies for enhancing intercultural effectiveness and communication across cultures.

1-5 Ensuring Intercultural Effectiveness

Being aware of your own culture and how it contrasts with others is a first step in learning intercultural skills. Another step involves recognizing barriers to intercultural accommodation and striving to overcome them. The digital age economy needs workers who can thrive on diverse teams and interact effectively with customers and clients at home and abroad. This section addresses how to overcome barriers to productive intercultural communication, develop strong intercultural skills, and capitalize on workplace diversity.

1-5a Avoiding Ethnocentrism and Stereotyping

The process of understanding and interacting successfully with people from other cultures is often hampered by two barriers: ethnocentrism and stereotyping. These barriers, however, can be overcome by developing tolerance and empathy, two powerful and effective aids to communication.

Ethnocentrism. The belief in the superiority of one's own ethnic group is known as **ethnocentrism**, an attitude found in all cultures. Ethnocentrism causes us to judge others by our own values. If you were raised in North America, values such as punctuality and directness probably seem right to you, and you may wonder why the rest of the world doesn't function in the same "sensible" fashion. A North American businessperson in an Arab or Asian country might be upset at time spent over coffee or other social rituals before any real business is transacted. In these cultures, however, personal relationships must be established and nurtured before negotiations may proceed.

Stereotypes. Our perceptions of other cultures sometimes cause us to form stereotypes about groups of people. A **stereotype** is an oversimplified, rigid perception of a behavioral pattern or characteristic applied uncritically to groups. For example, the Swiss are hardworking, efficient, and neat; Germans are formal, reserved, and blunt; Americans are loud, friendly, and impatient; Asians are gracious, humble, and inscrutable. These attitudes may or may not accurately describe cultural norms. When applied to individual business communicators, however, such stereotypes may be hurtful and cause misunderstandings. Look beyond superficial labels to discover individuals' unique qualities.

Tolerance and Open-Mindedness. As global markets expand and as our society becomes increasingly multiethnic, mutual tolerance is critical. **Tolerance** here means learning about those who are not like us; it means being open-minded and receptive to new experiences. With greater knowledge, patience, and compassion, tolerance may lead to understanding and acceptance.⁷² One of the best ways to become tolerant is to practice **empathy**, defined as trying to see the world through another's eyes. It means being less judgmental and more eager to seek common ground.

One way of promoting greater understanding is to work toward a common goal. An environmental studies center in Israel brings together Jews, Muslims, and Christians to tackle water scarcity in the Middle East, home to 10 of the 15 most water-starved countries in the world. The diverse student body is Jewish Israeli, Arab, and non-Middle Eastern. Aside from caring for the environment, the students attend peace-building forums to discuss race, religion, culture, and politics. The center develops one of the region's scarcest resources—trust.⁷³

Getting along with others is always a good policy, but doubly so in the workplace. Frequently job descriptions include statements such as *Must be able to communicate with diverse audiences*. The suggestions in the following section can help you prevent miscommunication in oral and written interactions across cultures.

1-5b Successful Oral Communication With Intercultural Audiences

When you have a conversation with someone from another culture, you can reduce misunderstandings by following these tips:

- **Use simple English.** Speak in short sentences (under 20 words) with familiar, short words. Eliminate puns, sport and military references, slang, and jargon (special business terms). Be especially alert to idiomatic expressions that can't be translated, such as *face the music* and *hit a home run*.
- **Speak slowly and enunciate clearly.** Avoid fast speech, but don't raise your voice. Overpunctuate with pauses and full stops. Always write and display numbers for all to see.
- **Encourage accurate feedback.** Ask probing questions, and encourage the listener to paraphrase what you say. Don't assume that a yes, a nod, or a smile indicates comprehension.



"[E]mployers are looking for people who have experienced the world and can bring a global perspective helping us to recognize our common engineering challenges and find solutions together. One way I have become a global citizen is through 'vol-untourism.' The term describes trips encompassing both volunteer work and tourism."⁷⁴

Rebecca Delaney,
engineering team leader,
associate director, Skidmore,
Owings & Merrill

- **Check frequently for comprehension.** Avoid waiting until you finish a long explanation to request feedback. Instead, make one point at a time and pause.
- **Observe eye messages.** Be alert to a glazed expression or wandering eyes. These tell you the listener is lost.
- **Accept blame.** If a misunderstanding results, graciously take responsibility for not making your meaning clear.
- **Listen without interrupting.** Curb your desire to finish sentences or to fill out ideas for the speaker. Keep in mind that North Americans abroad are often accused of listening too little and talking too much.
- **Smile when appropriate.** The smile is often considered the single most understood and most useful form of communication. In some cultures, however, excessive smiling may seem insincere.
- **Follow up in writing.** After conversations or oral negotiations, confirm the results and agreements with written messages. For proposals and contracts, hire a professional translator.

1-5c Successful Written Communication With Intercultural Audiences

When you write to someone from a different culture, you can improve your chances of being understood by following the following suggestions:

- **Consider local styles and conventions.** Learn how documents are formatted and how letters are addressed and developed in the intended reader's country. Decide whether to use your organization's preferred format or adjust to local styles.
- **Observe titles and rank.** Use last names, titles, and other signals of rank and status. Send messages to higher-status people; avoid sending copies to lower-rank people.
- **Hire a translator.** Engage a professional translator if (a) your document is important, (b) your document will be distributed to many readers, or (c) you must be persuasive.
- **Use short sentences and short paragraphs.** Sentences with fewer than 20 words and paragraphs with fewer than 8 lines are most readable.
- **Avoid ambiguity.** Include relative pronouns (that, which, who) for clarity in introducing clauses. Stay away from contractions (especially ones such as *Here's the problem*). Replace two-word verbs with clear single words (return instead of *bring back*; delay instead of *put off*; maintain instead of *keep up*). Avoid idioms (once in a blue moon), slang (my presentation really bombed), acronyms (ASAP for as soon as possible), abbreviations (DBA for doing business as), jargon (input, bottom line), and sports references (ballpark figure, slam dunk). Use action-specific verbs (buy a printer rather than get a printer).
- **Cite numbers carefully.** In international trade most nations use the metric system. In citing numbers, use figures (12) instead of spelling them out (twelve). Always convert dollar figures into local currency. Spell out the month when writing dates. In North America, for example, March 5, 2022, might be written as 3/5/2022, whereas in Europe the same date might appear as 5.3.2022.

1-5d Growing Workforce Diversity

While North American companies are expanding global operations and adapting to a variety of emerging markets, the domestic workforce is also becoming more diverse. This diversity has many dimensions—race, ethnicity, age, religion, gender, national

origin, disability, sexual orientation, and others. No longer, say the experts, will the workplace be predominantly Anglo-oriented or male-centered.

Today, people of color (individuals with African, Latinx or Hispanic, Asian, or Native American heritage) already comprise 39 percent of the U.S. population. New projections indicate that 2045 will be the year when communities of color will represent the majority of the U.S. population at 50.3 percent.⁷⁴ Women comprise nearly 50 percent of the workforce. Moreover, the share of the population over 65 will jump from 15 percent now to almost 22 percent in 2050. By 2030 one in five residents will have reached retirement age, outnumbering children for the first time in U.S. history.⁷⁵ Many of these older people will remain in the workforce. Thanks to technological advances, more disabled individuals are also joining the workforce.

What do all these changes mean for you? Simply put, your job may require you to interact with coworkers and customers from around the world. You will need to cooperate with individuals and teams. What's more, your coworkers may differ from you in race, ethnicity, gender, age, and other ways.

1-5e Understanding the Benefits of Diversity at Work

As society and the workforce become more diverse, successful communication among the various identity groups brings distinct advantages in three areas.

Consumers. Consumers want to deal with companies that respect their values and look like them. A diverse staff is better able to respond to the increasingly diverse customer base in local and world markets. The CEO of a PR firm embraces a diverse staff and customers: "Our team consists of more than 40 people who collectively speak 20 different languages." A CEO in PR urges fellow executives to "Tap into the diversity of your workplace to gain a deep understanding of your workforce and your potential customer base."⁷⁶

Work Teams. Leadership experts agree that diversity enhances creativity because inclusive teams bring novel perspectives to the table, resulting in better decision making and problem solving. One leadership consultant says that a culturally diverse group "can create an esprit de corps" and "a feeling of camaraderie among team members" resulting in successful cooperation. Aside from creativity and cohesion, diverse teams are 45 percent more likely to increase market share and 70 percent more likely to capture a new market.⁷⁸

Businesses. Organizations gradually realize that inclusivity is a critical bottom-line strategy to increase revenue, engage employees, and spur innovation. A McKinsey report found that gender and ethnically diverse executive teams were 33 percent more likely to lead their industry in profitability.⁷⁹ Researchers say that inclusion not only makes business sense but also benefits all workers. "The best workplaces forge bonds among co-workers of different political views, different backgrounds, different job titles," says Ann Nadeau, chief people officer at Great Place to Work.⁸⁰

Developing a diverse staff that can work together cooperatively is one of the biggest challenges and opportunities facing business organizations today.

1-5f Communicating in a Diverse Workplace

Acceptance and harmony do not happen automatically when dissimilar people work together. This means that organizations must commit to diversity. Harnessed effectively, diversity and inclusion can enhance productivity and propel a company to success. Mismanaged, it can become a drain on a company's resources. How companies deal with diversity will make all the difference in how they compete in a technology-driven global environment. The following suggestions can help you find ways to improve communication and interaction.

- **Seek training.** Especially if an organization is experiencing diversity problems, awareness-raising sessions or training programs may be helpful. Spend time learning



"Everyone can and should be adept at interacting with people from other cultures. Do research. Be curious. Don't make assumptions. For organizations, diversity works when there is commitment from the top, education programs and appointments made of people who are experienced at managing change across cultures."⁷⁹

Johann Xavier, managing partner, OZ advisory inc., Canada

about workforce diversity and how it can benefit organizations. Look upon diversity and inclusion as opportunities, not threats. Intercultural communication, team building, and conflict resolution are skills that can be learned.

- **Understand the value of difference.** Diversity makes an organization innovative and creative. Sameness fosters an absence of critical thinking called **groupthink**. Diversity can be a powerful antidote. Some researchers believe that if Wall Street had been more diverse, the financial crisis of 2008 could have been less severe.⁸¹ Economist and banker Mark Carney concurs: "Almost all decisions in finance are taken under uncertainty, making it especially important that decision makers are exposed to a range of views and engage in open debates with people whose perspectives challenge the prevailing wisdom."⁸²
- **Learn about your cultural self.** Begin to think of yourself as a product of your culture, and understand that your culture is just one among many. Take any opportunity to travel or study abroad, if possible. You will learn much, not only about other cultures but also about your own. Try to look at yourself from the outside. Do you see any reflex reactions and automatic thought patterns that are a result of your upbringing? These may be invisible to you until challenged by difference. Be sure to keep what works and yet be ready to adapt as environments change. Flexibility is an important survival skill.
- **Make fewer assumptions.** Be careful of seemingly insignificant, innocent workplace assumptions. For example, don't assume that everyone wants to observe the holidays with a Christmas party and a decorated tree. Celebrating only Christian holidays in December, January, and February excludes those who honor Hanukkah, Kwanzaa, Yule, and the Lunar New Year. Moreover, in workplace discussions don't assume anything about others' sexual orientations or attitudes toward marriage. For invitations, avoid phrases such as managers and their wives. Spouses or partners is inclusive. Valuing diversity means making fewer assumptions that everyone is like you or wants to be like you.
- **Build on similarities.** Look for areas in which you and others not like you can agree or at least share opinions. Be prepared to consider issues from many perspectives, all of which may be valid. Accept that there is room for various points of view to coexist peacefully. Although you can always find differences, it can be harder to find similarities. Look for common ground in shared experiences, mutual goals, and similar values.⁸³ Concentrate on your objective even when you may disagree on how to reach it.

Summary of Learning Outcomes

1 Describe how communication skills fuel career success in a challenging digital age marketplace.

- In an era of automation, augmented reality, and artificial intelligence, communication and other interpersonal skills can future-proof well-trained workers.
- Workers communicate more than ever; many collaborate in teams, which means that even technical fields require excellent communication skills.
- Employers expect new hires and other employees to project a professional image and possess superior interpersonal skills, including oral and written communication.
- Information age job challenges include rapid technological change and uncertainty, 24/7 availability, flatter management, an emphasis on teams, global competition, and a renewed focus on ethics.

Work Place Examples:

- Workplace bullying is a problem that impacts Job performance and Satisfaction. People who are the victims of this bullying often ~~lack~~ assertive comm. skills and find it challenging to speak up, request a raise, ask questions decline request.

Final Paper Topics:-

- 1) Assignment #2 (EOI, cover letter,
- 2) Assignment #1

Ap kaam kar rahe hoo Palc sa kissi or country ma kisse ka saht bo is ma hume cross culture, communication adaptability, ~~ste~~ process, strategies.

- 3) Cover letter

Job adverties de hoi honge us ka cover letter likhna honge 250, 300 words
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